What Is Happiness in My Mind?

Exploring Happiness from Different Cultural Perspectives

B12508026 戴偉璿

October 26, 2026

Contents

1 Introduction **3**

2 Methods **4**

2.1 Research Design 4

2.2 Literature Review 4

2.3 Participants 4

2.4 Questionnaire 5

3 Expected Results **5**

4 AI Disclosure **6**

Abstract

I used to believe that students in East Asia must be less happy than students in Western countries, because of the heavy academic pressure I have experienced. However, the World Happiness Report shows that Taiwan ranks almost the same as Canada, while young people in North America are becoming less happy. This made me wonder whether people in different cultures simply face different pressures and hold different ideas of happiness. Through a literature review, the lectures of this course, and conversations with friends in Taiwan, Japan, and Canada, this report explores how happiness differs across cultures, and then returns to myself to redefine what happiness means to me.

1 Introduction

A means average, B means below average, C means can't eat dinner, D means don't go home, F means find a new family.

Above is a common joke on the Internet that ridicules the rigid standards for Asian students. For me, it is not only a joke. I have lived in this system for 22 years. For the first three quarters of my life, almost everything was about grades. For the last quarter, it has been about anxiety for the future. Since academic stress has been linked to anxiety, depression, and poor sleep among students (Pascoe et al., 2020), I used to believe that students in Asia must be less happy than students in Western countries.

To check this idea, I looked at the World Happiness Report (WHR) 2026 (Helliwell et al., 2026b). At first, the ranking seems to support my belief. The United States ranked 23rd and Canada ranked 25th, while Japan ranked 61st, China ranked 65th, and South Korea ranked 67th. However, Taiwan is an exception. It ranked 26th, almost the same as Canada, and far ahead of the other Northeast Asian countries. This suggests that Northeast Asia should not be treated as one group.

What surprised me even more is that young people in North America and Western Europe are much less happy than they were 15 years ago (Helliwell et al., 2026a). The report suggests that heavy social media use may be one of the reasons, but it also points out that social media alone cannot fully explain this trend. This is quite different from my own experience. When I was growing up, the classmates with the best grades rarely spent much time on social media. Our pressure came from exams, not from what others posted online.

These findings made me realize that people in different places may live under different clouds. They may face different kinds of pressure, and they may even have different ideas of what happiness means. For example, when asked what makes life meaningful, people in most advanced economies put family first, but people in Taiwan put society first (Silver et al., 2021). If the meaning of happiness itself differs across cultures, then asking which country is "happier" may not be enough.

Therefore, in this report, I want to explore how happiness differs across cultures, focusing on Taiwan, Japan, and Canada. Through a literature review, the lectures of this course, and conversations with friends in these three places, I want to answer three questions. **First, how do people in different cultures understand happiness? Second, how do the mind, the body, and the environment, such as relationships, sleep, and the education system, shape students' happiness? Third, after looking at others, what is happiness in my mind, and how can I live a happier life?**

2 Methods

2.1 Research Design

This research combines a literature review with a small number of questionnaire-based interviews. The literature review is the main source of evidence. The interviews are not meant to represent all students in each country. Instead, I use them as examples to see whether the patterns in the literature also appear in the lives of real students.

2.2 Literature Review

I first collected literature with the help of a large language model, and then checked every reference against its original source. I plan to organize the literature into three parts.

First, I review large-scale data on happiness across countries, including the World Happiness Report (Helliwell et al., 2026a, 2026b) and the PISA reports on students' well-being (OECD, 2019). These sources show the overall pattern, but most of them are not about university students.

Second, I review studies on the factors that may affect students' happiness. Following the mind–body–environment framework of this course, I focus on academic pressure (mind), sleep and study hours (body), and interpersonal relationships, social media, and culture (environment).

Third, I connect these studies with the lectures of this course. The lecture by Prof. Pin-Hao Chen in Week 2 and the study of (Morelli et al., 2017) help me analyze students' interpersonal relationships. The lecture by Prof. Kai-Ping Yao in Week 6 guides how I measure happiness and design my questionnaire. Finally, the lecture by Prof. Po-Jang Hsieh in Week 7 provides an overall framework that I use to integrate all the factors above.

2.3 Participants

I plan to invite about 10 participants through my personal network: students living in different cities and counties in Taiwan, a Japanese friend, and a friend studying in Canada. The friend in Canada grew up in Taiwan, so her answers reflect the experience of moving

between two cultures rather than that of a typical Canadian student. She will also help me invite local Canadian students so that I can do a more complete comparison.

2.4 Questionnaire

I plan to design the questionnaire into five parts, most scales are introduced in the Week 6 lecture.

(i) **Overall happiness:** one 0–10 question, using the same format as the World Happiness Report (Helliwell et al., 2026b), and the Satisfaction With Life Scale (Diener et al., 1985; Wu & Yao, 2006).

(ii) **Peace of mind:** the Peace of Mind scale developed by Taiwanese researchers (Lee et al., 2013). Western scales focus on personal satisfaction, so I add this scale to capture a calmer, more balanced kind of happiness valued in East Asian cultures.

(iii) **Academic pressure:** the short version of the Fear of Failure scale (Conroy et al., 2002). Fear of failure is also measured in PISA 2018 (OECD, 2019), thus I can compare my results with that report.

(iv) **Daily life:** weekly class hours, study hours outside class, average sleep hours, sleep quality, and daily social media use. I ask about sleep quality separately because it is more strongly related to life satisfaction than sleep hours among university students (Pilcher et al., 1997).

(v) **Interpersonal relationships:** two questions adapted from (Morelli et al., 2017): "Who do you turn to when something bad happens?" and "Who do you usually have fun with?"

The questionnaire will also contain some open-ended questions, such as "What has made you feel happy recently?" To avoid leading participants toward certain answers, I will try to keep these questions neutral. I have not yet decided the exact wording, and I will refine it before sending the questionnaire.

3 Expected Results

I hope this report can help me gain a clearer picture in three aspects.

First, I hope to understand how people in different cultures define and pursue happiness, and whether the differences come from the level of happiness itself or from different ideas of what happiness means. Second, I hope to understand how the mind, the body, and the environment work together to shape students' happiness, and which factors are shared across cultures. Finally, by comparing others' experiences with my own, I hope to find out how much

my idea of happiness has been shaped by the system I grew up in. Based on this, I want to redefine what happiness means to me, and find some practical ways to live a happier life.

The formal report will contain the following content:

- My srarting point.
- Happiness across different cultures
- Factors that shape students' happiness
- How to live a happiness life

4 AI Disclosure

For this part of homework(i.e. proposal), I use Large Language Model(LLM) to assist me on the following parts:

- Literature collection and integration.
- Difficult content explanation.
- Refining Writing

For the fromal research, I may use LLMs to assist me on the following parts: ()

- Literature collection and integration.
- Difficult content explanation.
- Refining Writing.
- Questionnaire design.
- Translate questionnaires into different languages.

References

Conroy, D. E., Willow, J. P., & Metzler, J. N. (2002). Multidimensional fear of failure measurement: The performance failure appraisal inventory. *Journal of Applied Sport Psychology*, *14*(2), 76–90. https://doi.org/10.1080/10413200252907752

Diener, E., Emmons, R. A., Larsen, R. J., & Griffin, S. (1985). The satisfaction with life scale. *Journal of personality assessment*, *49*(1), 71–75.

Helliwell, J. F., Layard, R., Sachs, J. D., De Neve, J.-E., Aknin, L. B., & Wang, S. (2026a). Executive summary: Happiness and social media. In J. F. Helliwell, R. Layard, J. D. Sachs, J.-E. De Neve, L. B. Aknin, & S. Wang (Eds.), *World happiness report 2026*. Wellbeing Research Centre, University of Oxford. https://doi.org/10.18724/whr-ewft-vq17

Helliwell, J. F., Layard, R., Sachs, J. D., De Neve, J.-E., Aknin, L. B., & Wang, S. (Eds.). (2026b). *World happiness report 2026*. Wellbeing Research Centre, University of Oxford. https://www.worldhappiness.report/ed/2026/

Lee, Y.-C., Lin, Y.-C., Huang, C.-L., & Fredrickson, B. L. (2013). The construct and measurement of peace of mind. *Journal of Happiness studies*, *14*(2), 571–590.

Morelli, S. A., Ong, D. C., Makati, R., Jackson, M. O., & Zaki, J. (2017). Empathy and well-being correlate with centrality in different social networks. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, *114*(37), 9843–9847. https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1702155114

OECD. (2019). *PISA 2018 results (volume III): What school life means for students' lives*. https://doi.org/10.1787/acd78851-en

Pascoe, M. C., Hetrick, S. E., & Parker, A. G. (2020). The impact of stress on students in secondary school and higher education. *International journal of adolescence and youth*, *25*(1), 104–112.

Pilcher, J. J., Ginter, D. R., & Sadowsky, B. (1997). Sleep quality versus sleep quantity: Relationships between sleep and measures of health, well-being and sleepiness in college students. *Journal of Psychosomatic Research*, *42*(6), 583–596. https://doi.org/10.1016/S0022-3999(97)00004-4

Silver, L., Van Kessel, P., Huang, C., Clancy, L., & Gubbala, S. (2021). *What makes life meaningful?: Views from 17 advanced economies* (Vol. 221). Pew Research Center, Washington, DC.

Wu, C.-h., & Yao, G. (2006). Analysis of factorial invariance across gender in the taiwan version of the satisfaction with life scale. *Personality and Individual Differences*, *40*(6), 1259–1268.